to meet the needs of the hour. Within weeks, a fully computerized system became functional. A round-the-clock telephone facility for ensuring grievance redressal was made public, with the telephone number of the LG's control room regularly publicized. All the details were documented, computerized and analysed along with the correction time taken to redress the people's problems.

A mobile team to cross-check the validity of the reports received was put in place to reduce hoodwinking and hoax calls. A daily personal public hearing time was specified and adhered to. This kind of schedule enabled planning for the rest of the day regarding followups, implementation, coordination, analysis, reviews and meetings. Every grievance received whether by wireless/post/fax/telephone/ in person was computerized and the complainant received an official acknowledgement with a computer reference number with endorsements as to whom he would need to communicate with for follow-up. There used to be a monthly audit of all units receiving the mail, and a review date with Kiran of each unit was planned in advance and circulated to all for information. At the end of each month, a computer graphic of each unit's performance was circulated for all to see the results, on a comparative basis. It was a transparent record for performers and non-performers. The doers were appreciated by the LG, while the non-doers were given due advice and guidance by him. Nothing like this had ever happened before in such a sustained, methodical and regular manner. This system was appreciated, admired, replicated – and envied!

Here was a grievance redressal system, perhaps for the first time in the history of an Indian governor's office, where the governor became a people's governor.

As a part of the systemization, the LG initiated a people's participation scheme called the Citizen Warden Scheme. The LG appointed wardens from eminent citizens who had the requisite motivation to work for their neighbourhoods as office bearers of residents' associations. They included members of Rotary and Lions Clubs, retired members of the armed forces, civilian forces and others. They all received identity cards signed by the secretary to the LG, along with an appointment letter and the charter of duties. Thereafter, they reported their achievements on a monthly basis to the LG's Citizen Warden Desk headed by Inspector Sarabpal Singh. Kiran personally supervised this aspect. She used to regularly call for meetings of the citizen wardens and arrange coordination sittings with their area officers. A newsletter of the Citizen Warden Desk was also published to share the achievements, thoughts and ideas with all citizen wardens and government departments. From citizen wardens, the LG moved on to appoint citizen traffic wardens. All those who opted for duty in the area of road safety were given traffic violation record slips. They were also provided colourfully designed jackets so that they could be identified as citizen traffic wardens. These wardens assisted the regular law enforcement officials in checking traffic offences. In fact, the LG made these wardens his 'eyes and ears'.

This kind of people's participation was seen in some quarters as an open challenge to the elected representatives. Many so-called leaders felt threatened and insecure. Some declared open opposition to this move, while others supported it. But the citizens of Delhi welcomed it, as it was something they had always wanted. It represented democratic, responsive and participative governance. It earned wide acceptance and respect among the masses. However, the lurking questions were: how long would the system last? And how long would Kiran last? The answer was obvious, as long as the LG lasted!

This was exactly what happened, and fairly soon: in about a year and a half. With a change of government at the Centre in March 1998, as the LG is a Central Government appointee, Khanna was relieved of his charge. Soon after that a press statement was issued that the LG's house did not need a watchdog, while also admitting that a lot had been achieved. There were no answers from the new